

Title

Implementing structured palliative transitions across diverse European healthcare systems: protocol for a multi-stakeholder adaptation study

Abstract

Care transitions for advanced cancer patients often lack coordination across institutional boundaries, compromising quality and continuity. The Pal-Cycles intervention targets these gaps through structured communication and care planning protocols. Given substantial variation in European healthcare systems and end-of-life practices, successful implementation requires systematic adaptation to local contexts. This protocol describes the adaptation methodology for Pal-Cycles across seven countries spanning different healthcare funding models, regulatory environments, and cultural frameworks. Adaptation employs structured nominal group techniques with iterative refinement through multistakeholder consultation. Clinician working groups in each country will collaborate with patient/family advisory panels (where feasible) to refine intervention components while maintaining theoretical fidelity. Subsequent implementation uses a stepped-wedge design to evaluate outcomes including implementation reach, fidelity measures, and preliminary clinical and process endpoints. This paper details the systematic approach to cross-cultural adaptation of complex palliative care interventions.